Many variations of this Polish dish exist. Bacon, sauerkraut, and smoked Polish sausage are essential, but you could try lamb or beef instead of the duck or venison.

# bigos

**SERVES** 4 **PREP** 40 MINS **COOK** 2 HRS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

1 small Savoy cabbage, cored, ribs removed, leaves shredded
salt and freshly ground pepper
1lb 2oz (500g) sauerkraut, drained
3½oz (100g) smoked bacon, cubed
7oz (200g) smoked Polish sausage, sliced
7oz (200g) duck breast or lean venison, cubed
1 large red onion, diced
1 clove garlic, crushed
5½oz (150g) mushrooms, sliced
½ tsp smoked paprika
1 bay leaf
½ tsp juniper berries
1 tsp dried marjoram
½ tsp caraway seeds, crushed using a pestle and mortar
¾ cup red wine
1 cup beef stock

1 Heat a heavy saucepan over medium heat. Add the cabbage and cover with boiling water. Season with salt and pepper. Return to a simmer and cook for 10 minutes. Drain and reserve. Repeat with the sauerkraut, but simmer for 5 minutes. Drain, reserving the sauerkraut and the cooking liquid.

2 Heat a nonstick frying pan over medium heat. Cook the bacon until crisp. Place them on a platter lined with paper towels. Cook the sausage and duck or venison for 5 minutes, stirring, then add to the platter with the bacon. Set aside. Now cook the onion, garlic, and mushrooms in the same pan until softened. Then add to the saucepan, along with the cooked meats.

3 Place the saucepan over medium heat. Stir in the paprika, bay leaf, juniper berries, marjoram, and caraway seeds. Pour in the wine and stock. Bring to a simmer, stirring. Cover, reduce the heat a little, and simmer for 1 hour, stirring from time to time.

4 Add the boiled cabbage, stir, cover, and cook for 10 minutes, and then stir in the sauerkraut. Add some or all of the reserved cooking liquid (the mixture should be a thick soup rather than a stew). Simmer for another 15 minutes. Taste, adjust the seasoning, and serve very hot.